

TikTok: Gen Z's Dating Anxiety

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Generate Summary

US-based dating app Hinge's latest Gen Z D.A.T.E report reveals a global cohort (aged 18-28) craving emotional depth in relationships yet hesitant to initiate it. From fears of seeming cringe to social media making them feel emotionally exposed, we highlight the trends steering the Gen Z dating landscape in 2026.

- **Craving Emotional Connection:** An overwhelming **84%** of Gen Z daters want to make meaningful emotional connections. However, many hesitate to move the conversation beyond small talk. Gender dynamics play a role: **49%** of heterosexual Gen Z women wait for their date to open up, compared to just 17% of men. While **74% of Gen Z men and 70% of women** feel comfortable being emotionally open on a first date, fears of being “too much” or “cringe” hold many back. **Nearly half of men (47%)** and 39% of women say they worry about appearing “cringe”, which stops them from being vulnerable.
- **Working on IRL Emotional Connection:** Offline communication and intimacy pose a challenge: **32% of Gen Z men and 28% of women** say they don’t know how to build emotional closeness. Asking questions and keeping a conversation going is a huge factor in this. **Only 30% of heterosexual and 25% of LGBTQ+ daters** feel their date asks them enough questions – even though 62% of hetero and 61% of queer Gen Zers think they themselves ask their date enough questions.
- **Social Media Heightens Vulnerability:** **Half of Gen Z men and 45% of women** say social media makes them more hesitant to open up on dates, as they **feel watched by others** – making them self-censor and **worry** about how they’re perceived.
- **Gen Z & AI Dating Advice:** Artificial intelligence (AI) is becoming a trusted adviser. **Sixty per cent** of Gen Z daters aged 18-22 are open to receiving dating help from AI. Many already use it: **58% of Gen Z men and 40% of women** seek advice for opening lines, while more than half have used AI to craft responses.

See Seeking Low-Risk Intimacy in **10 Youth Trends to Watch 26/27** for more on how social media and a changing romantic landscape are shaping how Gen Zers approach intimacy.

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Video Transcript

Struggling with dating recently? Well, turns out you're not alone.

US-based dating app Hinge has released its latest Gen Z D.A.T.E report, and has found that Gen Z daters are seeking out emotional depth in relationships but are struggling to initiate it.

The report shows that 84% of 18–28-year-olds want meaningful connection, yet fears of being “cringe” hold nearly half of men and 39% of women back, despite most feeling comfortable being emotionally open on a first date.

Social media amplifies this hesitation of opening up on dates, with many saying that it makes them self-conscious and feel more guarded.

AI is increasingly becoming a tool for navigating dating, with 60% of 18–22-year-olds surprisingly open to guidance and many using it for opening lines or crafting responses.

Overall, Gen Z is seemingly seeking out low-risk intimacy in an era of heightened social scrutiny. So what do you think? Are you finding it hard to open up on dates?

